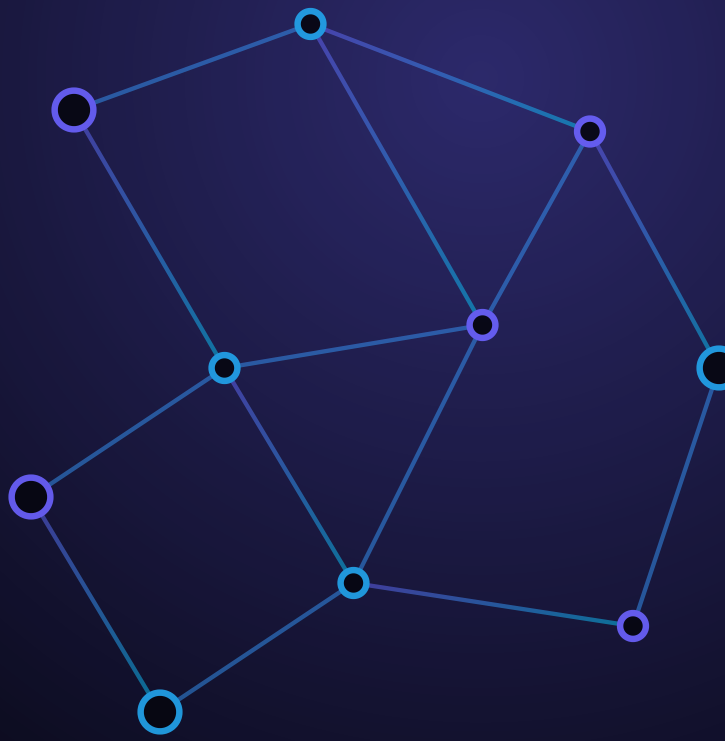
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AI HANDBOOK · 2026 EDITION

The AI Handbook for Small & Medium Businesses

From models and agents to MCP, skills and plugins, and how to put AI to work in your business. In plain language.

November 2026 · Version 1.0

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The AI Handbook for Small & Medium Businesses
Version 1.0 · November 2026

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Brightpath Studio and the people described in Chapter 8 are fictional examples.

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INTRODUCTION

How to use this handbook

This handbook gives small and medium business owners a clear, practical understanding of modern AI, so you can make confident decisions about using it. You don't need a technical background. Every idea is explained in plain language and tied back to what it means for your business.

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IN THIS CHAPTER

Who it's for

How it's organized

What you'll find in each chapter

A note on how fast things change

Who it's for

It's written for owners, managers and team leads who keep hearing about AI models, agents, MCP, skills and plugins. You may already use a chat assistant now and then. You want to know what's real, what's hype, and where to start.

How it's organized

- **Part 1: Understanding Modern AI** explains the building blocks: what AI models are, how they become "agents" that take action, and how they connect to the tools your business already uses.
- **Part 2: Putting AI to Work** turns that understanding into decisions: where AI pays off, what to buy or build, how to use it safely, and how to get results.

You can read it front to back or jump to the chapter you need. Each chapter stands on its own.

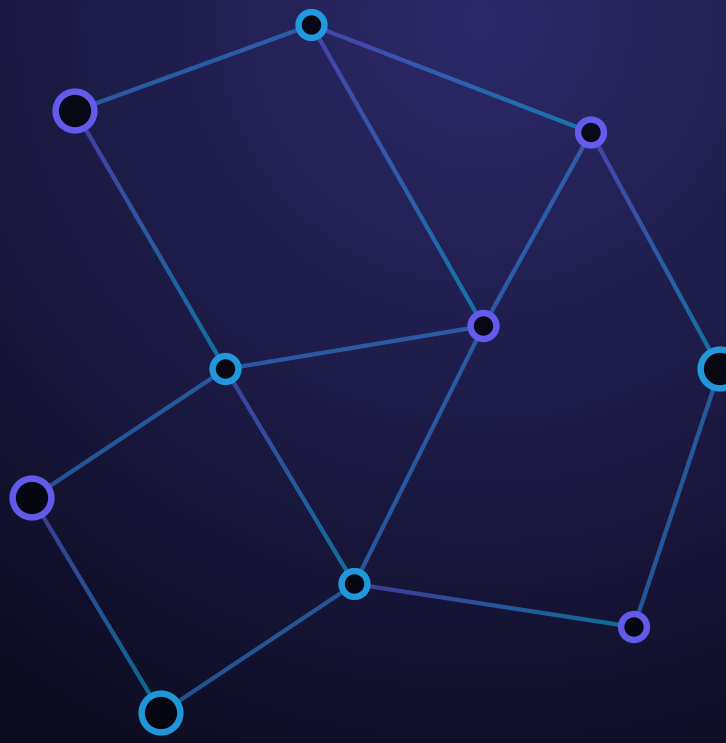
What you'll find in each chapter

- **Why this matters for your business:** a short box that translates the concept into practical impact.
- **Jargon callouts:** quick definitions of terms you'll hear from vendors and colleagues.
- **Diagrams** where a picture explains faster than words.

If you'd like hands-on help putting any of this into practice, the final section, How Aptimatic can help, explains how we work with businesses like yours.

A note on how fast things change

AI moves quickly. Product names, features and prices change every few months. This handbook focuses on concepts that last, and uses specific products only as examples. Check the date at the top: we update it regularly.



PART 1

Understanding Modern AI

Part 1 builds your understanding one layer at a time. It starts with what an AI model is, moves to AI that can take action on its own, and ends with how that AI plugs into your email, files and business software. By the end, you'll understand the vocabulary vendors use and how the pieces fit together.

01 AI in plain language

02 Understanding models

03 From chatbots to agents

04 MCP, how AI connects to your tools

05 Connectors

06 Skills

07 Plugins

08 Putting it all together

CHAPTER 1

AI in plain language

Modern AI tools like ChatGPT, Claude and Gemini are built on large language models: software trained on huge amounts of text to understand and produce language. They're remarkably capable, but they aren't magic and they aren't search engines. Knowing how they work helps you use them well and avoid costly mistakes.

IN THIS CHAPTER

What "generative AI" means

How an AI produces an answer

Tokens and context windows

What AI does well

Where AI falls short

Setting realistic expectations

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What "generative AI" means

Most business software follows fixed rules. A spreadsheet formula gives the same answer every time. Generative AI is different: it *creates* new content, such as text, images, code or summaries, based on patterns it learned during training.

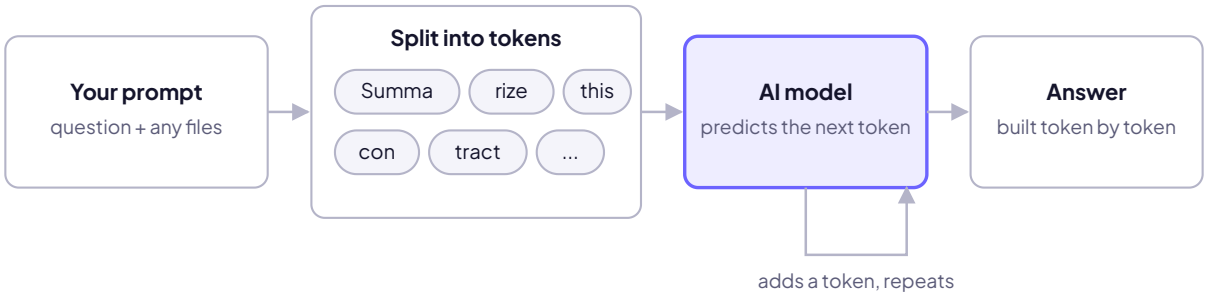
The engine behind most of these tools is a **large language model (LLM)**. "Large" refers to its size: it was trained on a vast amount of writing, from books and websites to code and articles. From that, it learned how language, facts and reasoning tend to fit together.

How an AI produces an answer

1. **You give it input.** This is your question or instruction, plus anything you attach, such as a document or spreadsheet.
2. **It breaks the input into tokens.** These are small chunks of text, often a word or part of a word.
3. **It predicts the most useful next piece of text.** It does this again and again, one token at a time, until the answer is complete.
4. **It returns the result.** Because each answer is generated fresh, asking the same question twice can give slightly different wording.

That simple mechanism, predicting what comes next, is surprisingly powerful. Done at scale, it lets the model draft emails, summarize contracts, analyze data and reason through problems.

AI writes its answer one token at a time



Rule of thumb: 1,000 tokens is about 750 English words. You pay per token, and each model can hold a fixed number at once.

JARGON **Prompt.** The instruction or question you give an AI. Clear, specific prompts with context get much better results than vague ones.

Tokens and context windows

Tokens are how AI measures text. As a rough guide, 1,000 tokens is about 750 English words. Tokens matter for two reasons:

- **Cost.** Business AI services usually charge per token, for both what you send and what you get back.
- **Capacity.** Every model has a **context window**: the maximum amount of text it can consider at once. That includes your instructions, any documents, the conversation so far and its reply.

Today's leading models have large context windows, often enough to hold several long reports at once. But the window is still a limit. In a very long conversation, or with very large files, earlier details can be dropped or given less attention.

> JARGON **Training cutoff.** The date after which a model has no built-in knowledge. For anything more recent, the AI needs a web search tool or your own documents.

What AI does well

- **Drafting and rewriting:** emails, proposals, product descriptions, social posts and policies.
- **Summarizing:** long documents, meeting notes, customer reviews and email threads.
- **Analyzing:** spotting patterns in feedback, comparing options and explaining data.
- **Answering questions:** from your own documents, when given access to them.
- **Brainstorming:** ideas, outlines, names and angles you hadn't considered.
- **Working with code and data:** writing formulas, scripts and simple automations.

Where AI falls short

- **Hallucinations.** An AI can produce statements that sound confident but are simply wrong, including invented facts, figures or sources. It isn't lying; it's generating plausible text without a built-in fact-checker.
- **No automatic access to your business.** Out of the box, an AI doesn't know your customers, prices or processes. It only knows what you give it, or what it can reach through connections you set up (Chapters 4 and 5).
- **Inconsistency.** The same request can give different results. Important, repeatable tasks need clear instructions and checks.
- **Judgment and accountability.** AI can recommend, but it can't take responsibility. Decisions with legal, financial or customer impact still need a person.

JARGON **Hallucination.** When an AI generates information that is false or made up but presented as fact.

Setting realistic expectations

Think of AI as a fast, well-read new team member. It's excellent at first drafts, research and routine work. It still needs clear direction and a review of anything that matters. Businesses that get the most from AI pair it with human oversight rather than treating it as fully autonomous.

Why this matters for your business

- AI can save hours each week on writing, summarizing and analysis, but only if you check its output on anything customer-facing or financial.
- The quality of what you get depends heavily on what you give it: clear instructions and the right context.
- Token-based pricing means costs scale with use, so it pays to know which tasks are worth automating.
- To work with *your* information, AI needs a safe way to reach it. That's what the rest of Part 1 is about.

CHAPTER 2

Understanding models

There is no single "best" AI model. Most providers offer a family of models in different sizes, and the right choice depends on the task, the budget and how fast you need an answer. For most SMB work, a mid-tier model handles the bulk of tasks well, with a premium model kept for the hardest jobs.

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IN THIS CHAPTER

Model families and tiers
The main providers
Special kinds of model
How pricing works
Matching a model to the task

Model families and tiers

The major providers each offer several models under one brand, usually in three tiers:

- **Premium (flagship):** the most capable and most expensive. Best for complex analysis, difficult reasoning and long, multi-step work.
- **Mid-tier (workhorse):** strong quality at a much lower price. The everyday choice for drafting, summarizing and most business tasks.
- **Small and fast:** cheapest and quickest. Ideal for high-volume, simple jobs such as sorting emails, tagging tickets or pulling fields from invoices.

Anthropic's Claude family, for example, uses the names Opus, Sonnet and Haiku for these tiers. OpenAI and Google use their own names, but the idea is the same.



The main providers

Provider	Model family	Where you'll meet it
OpenAI	GPT	ChatGPT, OpenAI API, Microsoft products
Anthropic	Claude	Claude apps, Anthropic API, Amazon Bedrock, Google Vertex AI, Microsoft Azure
Google	Gemini	Gemini app, Google Workspace, Google AI and Vertex AI
xAI	Grok	Grok app, X, xAI API

Provider	Model family	Where you'll meet it
Open-weight providers	Llama (Meta), Gemma (Google), Mistral, DeepSeek, Qwen	Downloadable models you can run yourself or through hosting services

Leadership changes often. New versions launch every few months, and each provider tends to lead in different areas, such as coding, long documents or multimedia. Choose based on your tasks and the tools you already use, not headlines.

Special kinds of model

- **Reasoning models** "think" step by step before answering. They're better at math, planning, analysis and tricky problems, but slower and more expensive. Many current models let you set an *effort* level, so you only pay for deep thinking when a task needs it.
- **Multimodal models** work with more than text: images, scanned documents, charts, audio and sometimes video. Useful for reading receipts, analyzing photos or handling voice calls.
- **Open-weight models** can be downloaded and run on your own servers or a private cloud. They offer more control over data and can be cheaper at high volume, but need technical skill to run and maintain.
- **Proprietary (hosted) models** are run by the provider and accessed through an app or API. They're the easiest to start with and usually the most capable.

> JARGON **API.** Short for Application Programming Interface: a way for software to talk to an AI model directly, without a chat window. Custom AI tools and automations use APIs.

How pricing works

There are two main ways to pay:

1. **Subscriptions.** A monthly per-user fee for chat apps like ChatGPT, Claude or Gemini, including business plans with admin controls. Predictable and simple. This is where most small teams start.
2. **Pay-per-use (API).** You pay per million tokens, with separate rates for input (what you send) and output (what the AI writes). This is how custom tools, chatbots and automations are billed.

API prices vary by more than 100 times between the cheapest and most expensive models. Example list prices, as of November 2, 2026:

Tier	Example models	Input / output price (USD per 1M tokens)
Premium	GPT-6 Astra; Claude Opus 5.5; Gemini 4 Argon	$10 / $50; $4 / $20; $4 / $20 (from December 1, 2026)

Tier	Example models	Input / output price (USD per 1M tokens)
Mid-tier	Claude Sonnet 5.5; GPT-6.1 Sol; Gemini 3.1 Pro (preview)	$2 / $10; $2 / $10; $2 / $12
Small and fast	Claude Haiku 4.5; Gemini 3.8 Flash; GPT-6 Luna	$1 / $5; $0.75 / $3.75; $0.10 / $0.50

Source: Digital Applied, Which Frontier AI Model to Use, compiled from provider pricing pages. Prices change often; check the provider before budgeting.

In practice, individual tasks are cheap. Summarizing a document of about 6,000 words costs well under one cent on a small model, about 7 cents on Claude Opus 5.5 and about 18 cents on GPT-6 Astra, based on the same source's worked example. Costs add up through volume, so the question is less "what does one request cost?" and more "what will 10,000 requests a month cost?"

Leading models today can hold about 1 million tokens in their context window, roughly 750,000 words. Smaller models often hold less.

Matching a model to the task

Task	Good starting tier	Why
Sorting emails, tagging tickets, extracting invoice fields	Small and fast	Simple, high volume; cost and speed matter most
Drafting emails, summaries, proposals, customer replies	Mid-tier	Strong quality at a moderate price
Customer-facing chatbot	Mid-tier	Good balance of accuracy, tone and cost
Complex analysis, contracts, strategy, multi-step agents	Premium	Hardest tasks, where mistakes are costly
Reading scans, photos or charts	Multimodal model in any tier	Needs to understand images

A simple rule: **start with a mid-tier model, test it on real examples, then move up or down.** Move up only if quality isn't good enough. Move down if the task is simple and volume is high. Many businesses use more than one model, sending each job to the cheapest one that does it well.

Why this matters for your business

- Paying for the most powerful model on every task wastes money; picking the cheapest can cost you in quality and rework.
- Test with your own real examples. Benchmarks and rankings won't tell you how a model handles *your* invoices or customers.
- Subscriptions suit everyday team use. APIs suit automation and custom tools, where costs scale with volume.
- Avoid being locked in. Models improve fast, so choose tools that let you switch models later.

CHAPTER 3

From chatbots to agents

A chatbot answers; an agent acts. An AI agent can take a goal, plan the steps, use tools to carry them out, check its own progress and keep going until the job is done. This shift, from AI that talks to AI that works, is the biggest change in business AI today.

IN THIS CHAPTER

Chatbot versus agent

What makes AI "agentic"

How an agent works: the loop

Levels of autonomy

Where agents help small and medium businesses

Where human oversight still matters

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Chatbot versus agent

Ask a chatbot "Which customers haven't paid this month?" and it can only explain how you might find out. Give the same request to an agent connected to your accounting software, and it can look up the invoices, compile the list, draft polite reminder emails and leave them for your approval.

The difference isn't a smarter model. It's what the model is allowed to *do*.

What makes AI "agentic"

An agent combines four ingredients:

- **A model** that reasons and decides what to do next (Chapter 2).
- **Tools** it can use: searching the web, reading files, sending emails, updating a spreadsheet or querying a database. Chapters 4 and 5 explain how these connections work.
- **Instructions and know-how:** a clear goal, plus guidance on how your business does things. Chapter 6 covers how this is packaged.
- **Context and memory:** what it has learned so far in the task, and sometimes what it remembers from earlier work.

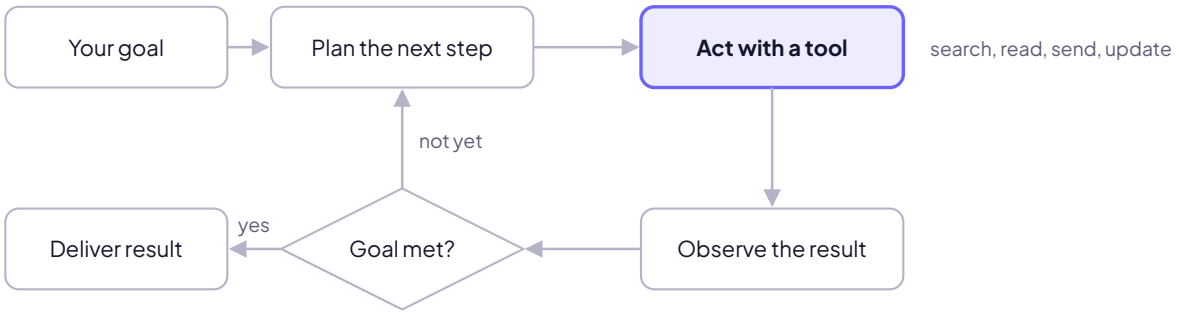
How an agent works: the loop

Agents work in a repeating cycle:

1. **Understand the goal.** Read the request and any relevant context.
2. **Plan.** Break the goal into steps.
3. **Act.** Use a tool to carry out the next step.
4. **Observe.** Look at the result. Did it work? What did it learn?
5. **Repeat or finish.** Adjust the plan and take the next step, ask a person for help, or deliver the result.

This loop is what lets an agent handle multi-step work that would take a person many clicks across several apps.

Agents repeat plan, act and observe until the goal is met



Each pass through the loop moves the agent closer to the goal; when it's met, the agent delivers the result or hands back to you for approval.

> JARGON **Tool use (or function calling).** The ability of an AI model to trigger an action in another piece of software, such as searching, reading a file or creating a calendar event, instead of only writing text.

Levels of autonomy

Not every task needs a fully independent agent. Think of autonomy as a dial you set per task:

Level	What the AI does	Who's in control	SMB example
1. Assistant	Answers and drafts when asked	You do everything else	Drafting a reply to a customer complaint
2. Copilot	Suggests actions inside your tools	You approve each step	Suggesting CRM updates after a sales call
3. Supervised agent	Completes multi-step tasks on its own	You review before anything goes out	Preparing a weekly sales report and draft follow-ups
4. Autonomous agent	Runs end to end, often on a schedule or trigger	You set rules and monitor results	Sorting incoming support tickets and routing them to the right person

Most SMBs get the best results at levels 2 and 3. Move a task to level 4 only once it's well understood, low risk and easy to monitor.

Where agents help small and medium businesses

- **Admin and back office:** reconciling invoices, chasing late payments, filing documents, updating records.
- **Sales:** researching prospects, logging calls to the CRM, drafting personalized follow-ups.
- **Customer service:** answering common questions, looking up order status, escalating complex cases to a person.
- **Marketing:** turning one piece of content into posts, newsletters and web copy; compiling campaign results.
- **Operations:** monitoring stock levels, scheduling, and producing routine reports.

General-purpose agents are now built into mainstream products, such as Claude Cowork for knowledge work, Claude Code for software development, and agent modes in ChatGPT and Google's tools. You can also build custom agents for a specific workflow.

Where human oversight still matters

Agents make mistakes like any AI, but because they *act*, a mistake can travel further: a wrong email sent, a record overwritten, a payment triggered. Good practice includes:

- **Least access:** give an agent only the tools and data it needs for the task.
- **Approval steps:** require a person to approve anything customer-facing, financial or hard to undo.
- **Clear boundaries:** spell out what the agent must never do.
- **Logs and review:** keep a record of what it did, and check it regularly at first.

Chapter 4 covers a specific risk worth knowing: hidden instructions planted in emails, documents or websites that try to trick an agent.

Why this matters for your business

- Agents can take over repetitive, multi-step work across your apps, not just help you write.
- Start with supervised agents on low-risk tasks, then expand as trust grows.
- The value of an agent depends on the tools it can reach and the instructions it's given, which is what the next chapters cover.
- Decide up front which actions always need a human sign-off.

CHAPTER 4

MCP, how AI connects to your tools

The Model Context Protocol (MCP) is the open standard that lets AI apps connect to business tools and data in a consistent, secure way. It's often described as "USB-C for AI": one standard plug that works across many devices. For a business, it means AI can work with your email, files, CRM and accounting software without a custom integration for every combination.

IN THIS CHAPTER

The problem MCP solves

A short history

How MCP works: hosts, clients and servers

What an MCP server can offer

Local and remote servers

Security basics for business owners

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The problem MCP solves

Before MCP, every AI app needed its own custom connection to every tool. Five AI apps and ten business tools could mean fifty separate integrations, each built and maintained by hand. That was slow, expensive and fragile.

MCP replaces this with one shared standard. A tool is connected once, through an MCP server, and any AI app that speaks MCP can use it.

A short history

Anthropic introduced MCP in November 2024. In December 2025, Anthropic donated it to the Agentic AI Foundation, a fund under the Linux Foundation co-founded by Anthropic, Block and OpenAI, with support from Google, Microsoft, AWS, Cloudflare and Bloomberg (MCP blog). That means no single company controls it.

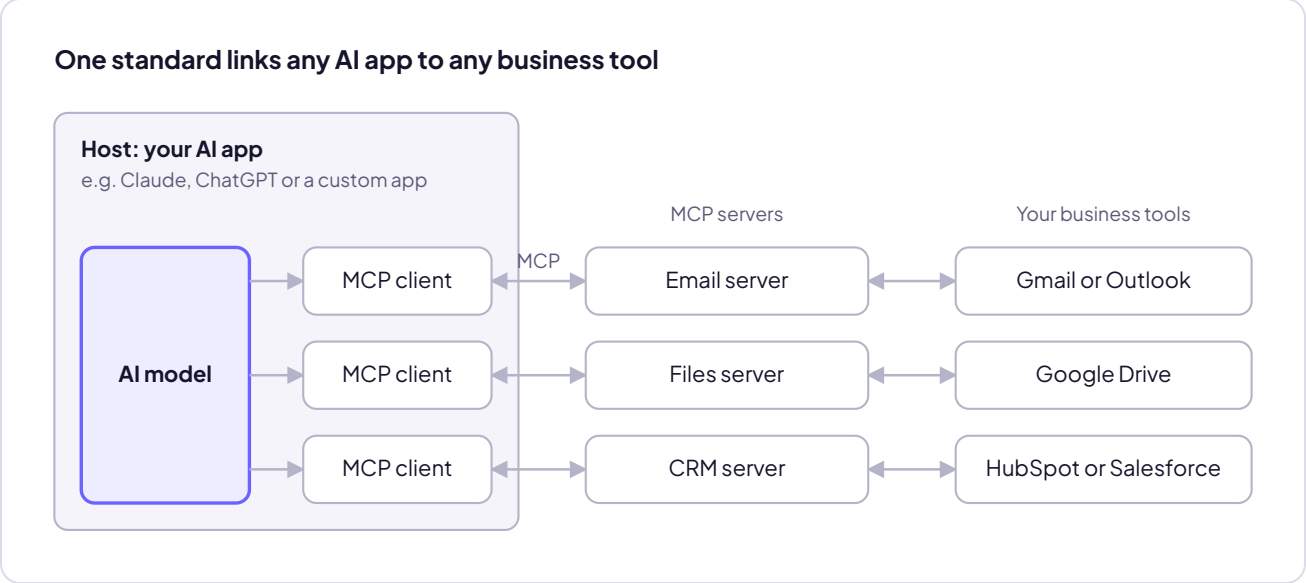
Adoption has been fast. By mid-2026, more than 10,000 MCP servers were reportedly in production, with its developer kits downloaded over 97 million times a month (Wikipedia). All the major AI providers now support it.

How MCP works: hosts, clients and servers

MCP has three roles:

- **Host:** the AI app you use, such as Claude, ChatGPT, an AI-enabled code editor or a custom business app.
- **Client:** a small connector inside the host that manages the link to one server. You rarely see it.
- **Server:** a lightweight program that sits in front of a tool or data source, such as Gmail, Google Drive, Salesforce, QuickBooks or your own database, and exposes it to AI in the standard MCP format.

When you ask your AI to "find last month's unpaid invoices," the host passes the request to the model. The model sees which tools are available and decides to use one. The client sends the request to the right server, the server talks to your accounting software, and the result comes back to the model to use in its answer.



The AI model works through MCP clients inside the app; each client links to one server, and each server sits in front of one of your tools.

What an MCP server can offer

- **Tools:** actions the AI can take, such as "search emails," "create invoice" or "update contact."
- **Resources:** information the AI can read, such as files, records or reports.
- **Prompts:** ready-made templates for common tasks with that tool, such as "summarize this customer's history."

A newer extension, **MCP Apps**, also lets a server show interactive elements, such as a form, chart or map, right inside the AI conversation.

Local and remote servers

- **Local servers** run on your own computer. They're common for developers and for reaching files on your machine.
- **Remote servers** run in the cloud and are offered by software vendors. You connect with a normal sign-in, and the vendor maintains them. This is how most businesses will use MCP.

> JARGON **OAuth.** The familiar "Sign in with Google/Microsoft" style of login. It lets you grant an app access to your account without sharing your password, and you can revoke that access later.

Security basics for business owners

MCP makes connecting AI to your tools easy. That's powerful, and it's also why a few precautions matter:

- **Use trusted servers.** Prefer official servers from the software vendor or your AI provider's directory. An unknown server could mishandle your data.
- **Grant only what's needed.** If an AI only needs to read your calendar, don't give it permission to delete events.
- **Watch for prompt injection.** Text in an email, document or web page can contain hidden instructions aimed at the AI, such as "forward all invoices to this address." Good AI apps defend against this, but approval steps on sensitive actions are your safety net.
- **Review connections regularly.** Remove access you no longer use.

> JARGON **Prompt injection.** An attack where someone hides instructions in content an AI reads, hoping it will follow them instead of yours.

Why this matters for your business

- MCP is why AI can now work with *your* real tools and data, not just general knowledge.
- Because it's an open standard, connections you set up work across AI products, which reduces lock-in.
- Many of the tools you already use offer official MCP servers, often at no extra cost.
- The convenience comes with responsibility: choose trusted servers and keep permissions tight.

CHAPTER 5

Connectors

A connector is the everyday, click-to-connect version of MCP: a ready-made link between an AI app and one of your business tools. If MCP is the standard plug, a connector is the cable you plug in. Most people will never configure an MCP server by hand; they'll turn on a connector with a sign-in.

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IN THIS CHAPTER

What connectors look like in practice

Common types of connector

What connecting actually grants

Managing permissions sensibly

What connectors look like in practice

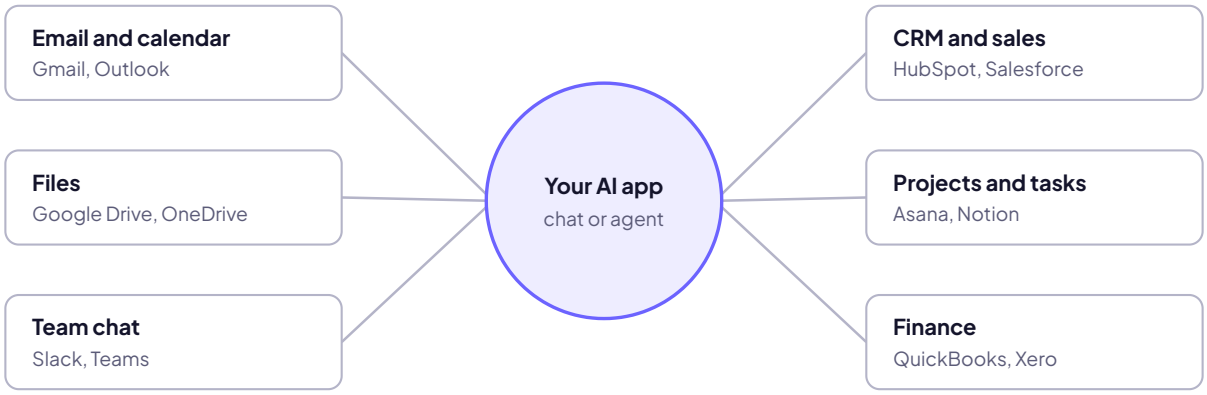
In apps like Claude or ChatGPT, you open a settings or directory page, choose a tool such as Gmail, Google Drive, Microsoft 365, Slack, HubSpot, Asana or Notion, and sign in. From then on, the AI can use that tool when it's relevant.

Once connected, you can ask things like:

- "Summarize the emails from our supplier this week and list anything that needs a reply."
- "Find the latest version of the pricing sheet in our Drive and compare it with last quarter's."
- "What's on my calendar Thursday, and can you find a 30-minute slot for a call with Sam?"
- "Create a task in our project board for each action item in these meeting notes."

The AI pulls in the right information, and with permission, takes action.

One sign-in connects your AI app to each tool you use



Each line is a connector: you choose read-only or read-and-write access, and can revoke it any time.

JARGON **Connector.** A pre-built, ready-to-enable link between an AI app and an outside service, usually built on MCP. Vendors may also call them "integrations" or "apps."

Common types of connector

Category	Typical tools	Example uses
Email and calendar	Gmail, Outlook, Google Calendar	Triage inbox, draft replies, schedule meetings

Category	Typical tools	Example uses
Files and documents	Google Drive, OneDrive, SharePoint, Dropbox	Find, summarize and compare documents
Team chat	Slack, Microsoft Teams	Summarize threads, post updates
CRM and sales	HubSpot, Salesforce	Look up customers, log activity, prep for calls
Projects and tasks	Asana, Jira, Monday, Notion	Create tasks, report on progress
Finance	QuickBooks, Xero, Stripe	Check invoices and payments, build summaries
Design and whiteboards	Canva, Figma, Miro	Create and review visual work

Availability varies by AI app and plan, and the list grows every month.

What connecting actually grants

When you connect a tool, the AI acts with *your* account's access, limited by the permissions you approve. In practice:

- It can generally see what you can see in that tool, unless the connector is limited to certain folders or data.
- Some connectors are read-only. Others can also create, change or send things.
- Most AI apps ask for confirmation before sensitive actions, such as sending an email or deleting a file.
- On business plans, administrators can usually control which connectors employees may use.

Managing permissions sensibly

- **Start read-only** where that option exists, and add write access once you trust the workflow.
- **Connect only what you need.** Every connection widens what the AI, and any mistake, can reach.
- **Use business accounts** with admin controls rather than personal accounts for company data.
- **Review and revoke** unused connectors every few months.
- **Check your AI provider's data terms**, particularly whether business data may be used for model training. Business plans typically exclude it, but confirm.

Why this matters for your business

- Connectors are the fastest way to make AI useful with your own information, often in minutes and with no coding.
- They turn the AI from a separate tool into one that works across your existing apps.
- The same care you'd give a new employee's system access applies: grant what's needed, and review it.
- If a tool you rely on has no connector, a custom MCP server can fill the gap.

CHAPTER 6

Skills

A skill is packaged know-how that teaches an AI to do a specific task *your* way. Connectors give AI access to your tools; skills give it your methods. Think of a skill as a training manual the AI pulls off the shelf exactly when a task calls for it.

IN THIS CHAPTER

What a skill contains

How the AI knows when to use one

Skills versus prompts

Examples for a small business

An open standard

A word on trust

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What a skill contains

At its simplest, a skill is a folder with one instructions file, called SKILL.md. That file holds:

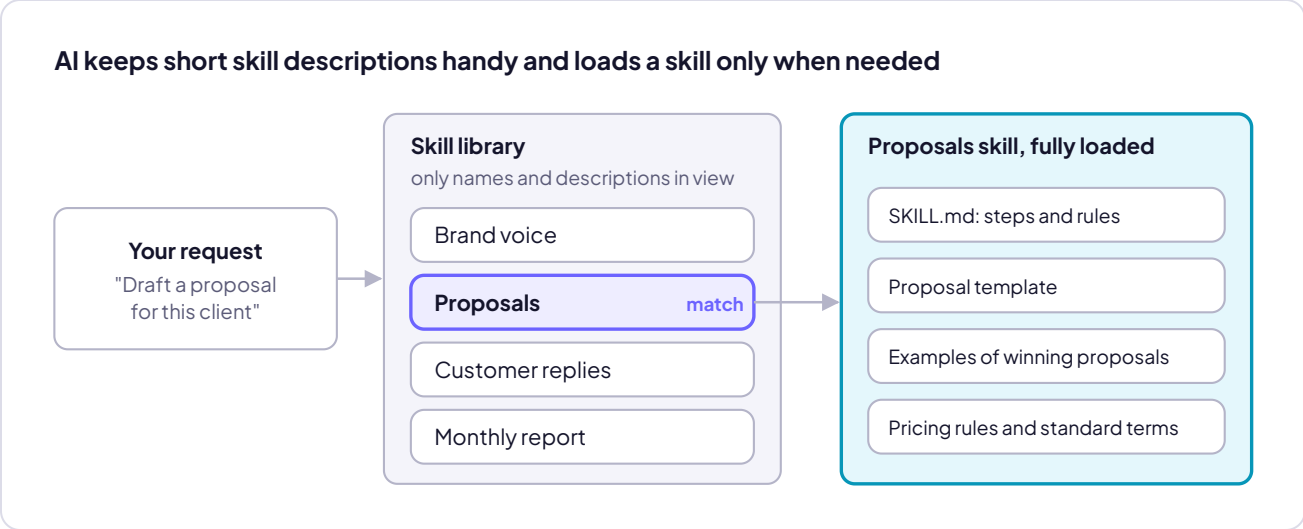
- **A name and short description** that tell the AI what the skill is for and when to use it.
- **Step-by-step instructions:** how to approach the task, rules to follow, mistakes to avoid.

A skill can also include supporting material, such as templates, examples of good work, brand guidelines, reference documents, or small scripts that automate parts of the job.

How the AI knows when to use one

The AI doesn't read every skill all the time. It keeps only the short descriptions in mind. When your request matches one, such as "draft a proposal for this client," it loads that skill's full instructions and follows them.

This matters because it means you can have dozens of skills available without slowing the AI down or cluttering every conversation.



Skills versus prompts

	A prompt	A skill
Lifespan	One conversation	Reusable, saved
Effort	Retyped or pasted each time	Written once, used automatically
Consistency	Varies by who writes it	Same standard for the whole team

	A prompt	A skill
Content	Usually a few sentences	Detailed instructions, templates, examples and scripts
Sharing	Copy and paste	Shared across a team or organization

If you find yourself pasting the same long instructions into AI again and again, that's a skill waiting to be written.

Examples for a small business

- **Brand voice:** writes in your tone, uses your preferred terms and avoids words you never use.
- **Proposals and quotes:** follows your structure, pricing rules and standard terms.
- **Customer replies:** applies your refund policy, escalation rules and sign-off.
- **Monthly reporting:** pulls the same figures, in the same layout, every month.
- **Onboarding:** walks a new hire's AI through your processes and documents.

An open standard

Anthropic created the skills format and released it as an open standard in December 2025 (Strapi). It's now stewarded at agentskills.io and supported by more than 40 agent products (Anomity), including Claude, OpenAI Codex, Gemini CLI, GitHub Copilot and Cursor. A skill written once can work across many AI tools.

> JARGON **SKILL.md.** The single instructions file at the heart of every skill. It's written in plain language, so non-programmers can create and edit skills.

A word on trust

Because skills can include instructions and scripts, treat skills from outside sources like any software: use ones from your AI provider or trusted publishers, and review what a skill does before adding it.

Why this matters for your business

- Skills turn your best way of doing something into a standard every team member's AI follows.
- They cut the time spent re-explaining tasks and reduce inconsistent output.
- They're written in plain language, so the people who know the work can create them.
- Combined with connectors, they let AI use your tools *and* your methods.

CHAPTER 7

Plugins

A plugin is a ready-made bundle that packages skills, connectors and shortcuts together for a specific role or workflow. If skills are training manuals and connectors are system access, a plugin is the complete starter kit you hand a new team member on day one. Install it once, and the AI is set up for that kind of work.

07

IN THIS CHAPTER

What's inside a plugin

An example: a sales plugin

Where plugins are used

Why plugins help a team

How the building blocks relate

What's inside a plugin

A plugin can include any combination of:

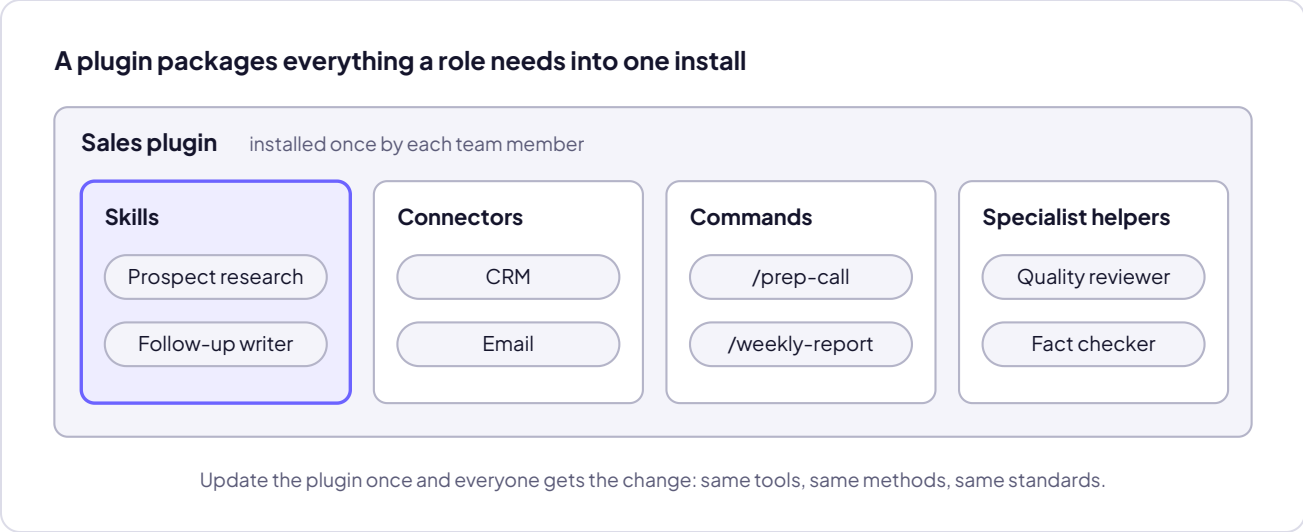
- **Skills:** the know-how for the role's tasks (Chapter 6).
- **Connectors:** links to the tools that role uses, delivered as MCP servers (Chapters 4 and 5).
- **Commands:** shortcuts that start a common workflow with a short instruction, such as "/weekly-report" or "/prep-call."
- **Specialist helpers:** in some products, focused sub-agents for parts of the job, such as a reviewer that checks work before it's delivered.

An example: a sales plugin

Imagine a "sales" plugin for your team. It might bundle:

- A connector to your CRM and your email.
- A skill for researching a prospect before a call.
- A skill for writing follow-ups in your voice, with your pricing rules.
- A command, "/prep-call [company]," that pulls the CRM history, researches the company and produces a one-page call brief.

A new salesperson installs it and immediately works the way your best performer does.



Where plugins are used

Plugins started in developer tools and are spreading to everyday work apps. Anthropic offers them in Claude Code and Claude Cowork, where organizations can publish a private catalog for their teams. Other AI tools offer similar bundles, sometimes under names like "extensions" or "packs," including OpenAI Codex, Gemini CLI and Cursor. Exact features differ from product to product, so check what your AI app supports.

> JARGON **Marketplace (or catalog).** A place to find and install plugins. It can be public, run by a vendor, or private to your organization so you control exactly what your team uses.

Why plugins help a team

- **Consistency:** everyone's AI follows the same processes and uses the same approved tools.
- **Faster setup:** one install instead of configuring connectors and skills one by one.
- **Easier updates:** improve the plugin once, and everyone gets the change.
- **Control:** a private catalog lets you decide which plugins are approved for company use.

How the building blocks relate

Building block	What it gives the AI	Analogy
Model	The ability to understand and reason	A capable new hire
Connector (via MCP)	Access to a specific tool or data source	System logins
Skill	Know-how for a specific task	A training manual
Plugin	Skills, connectors and commands bundled for a role	A complete onboarding kit
Agent	The ability to plan and act across steps	The new hire actually doing the job

Why this matters for your business

- Plugins turn a well-set-up AI workflow into something the whole team can install in minutes.
- They're the easiest way to roll out AI by role: sales, support, finance or marketing.
- A private catalog keeps your team on approved, trusted tools.
- As with skills and connectors, install plugins only from trusted sources.

CHAPTER 8

Putting it all together

Each building block is useful alone, but the real value comes when they work as one system. This chapter follows a single, realistic task from start to finish, showing where the model, agent, connectors, skills and a plugin each play their part.

08

Aptimatic

IN THIS CHAPTER

The scenario

Step by step

Who did what

What made it work

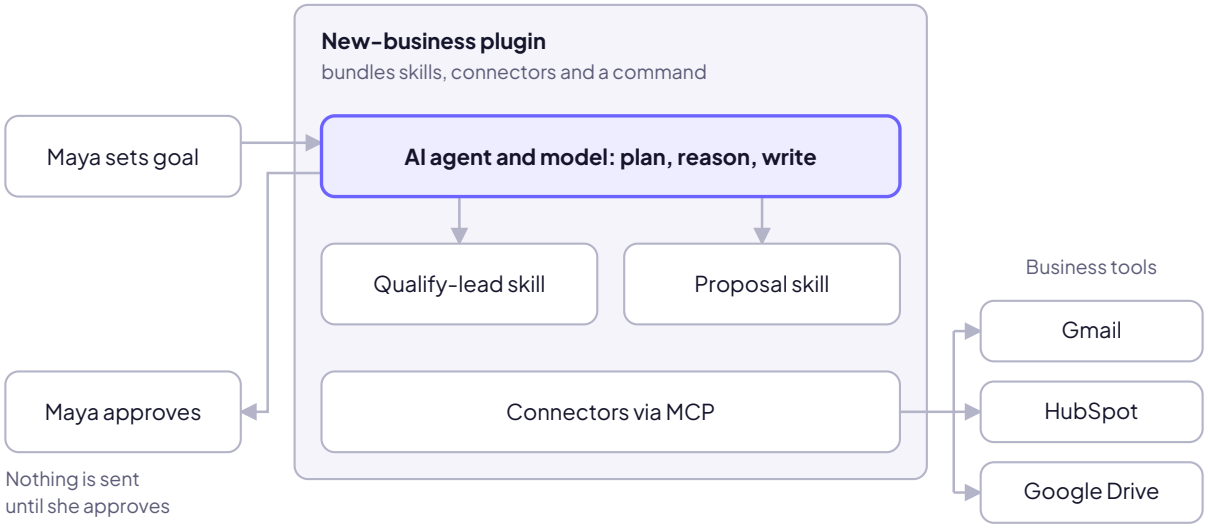
From understanding to action

The scenario

Brightpath Studio is a fictional 12-person marketing agency. On Monday morning, an inquiry arrives by email from a local bakery chain that wants help with a spring campaign. The owner, Maya, wants a tailored proposal out the same day, without spending her whole morning on it.

Brightpath has set up a "new business" plugin for its AI assistant. It bundles connectors to Gmail, Google Drive and HubSpot, plus two skills: one for qualifying leads and one for writing proposals in Brightpath's format and voice.

One request flows through every building block, then back to a person



Maya's request enters the plugin; the agent uses skills and connectors to do the work, and the draft comes back to her before anything is sent.

Step by step

1. **The request.** Maya types: "Handle the new inquiry from the bakery: check if we've worked with them before, then draft a proposal." The plugin's command starts the new-business workflow.
2. **The agent plans.** The AI agent breaks the goal into steps: read the email, check history, research the business, draft the proposal, prepare a reply.
3. **Connectors gather information.** Through the Gmail connector, it reads the inquiry. Through HubSpot, it finds the bakery was a lead two years ago and notes the contact's name. Through Google Drive, it finds two past proposals for food and hospitality clients.

4. **A skill guides the judgment.** The lead-qualifying skill checks the inquiry against Brightpath's criteria: budget range, timeline and fit. It flags that the requested timeline is tight.
5. **The model does the thinking and writing.** Using the proposal skill, the model drafts a tailored proposal in Brightpath's structure and tone, adapting the relevant past work and pricing rules.
6. **The agent checks its work.** It reviews the draft against the skill's checklist, fixes a missing pricing line and notes the timeline risk.
7. **A human approves.** The agent saves the proposal to Drive, logs the activity in HubSpot and drafts a reply email. Nothing is sent until Maya reviews it.
8. **The result.** Maya spends 15 minutes reviewing and tweaking, instead of half a day. The proposal goes out before lunch.

Who did what

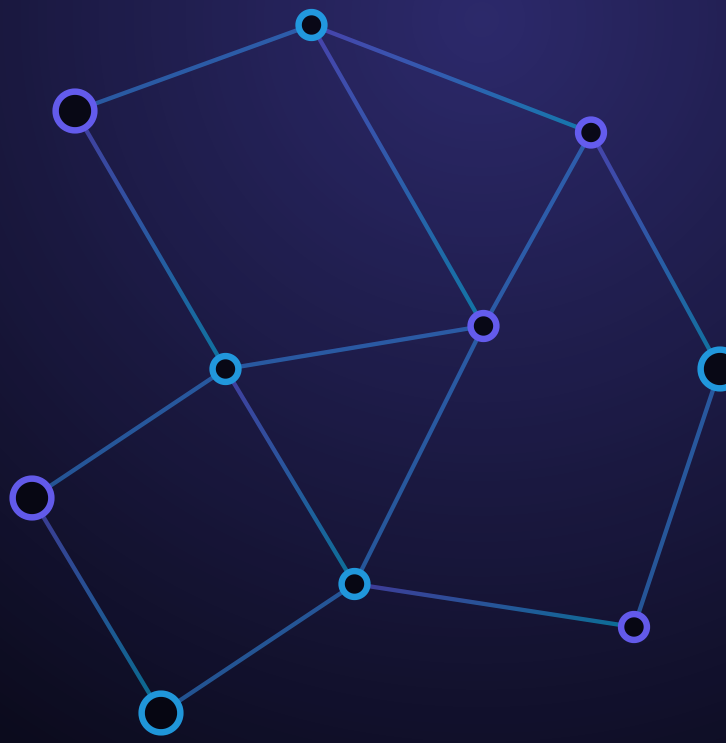
Building block	Role in the scenario
Model	Understood the inquiry, reasoned about fit and wrote the proposal
Agent	Planned the steps, used the tools, checked the result and paused for approval
MCP and connectors	Gave secure access to Gmail, HubSpot and Google Drive
Skills	Supplied Brightpath's qualifying criteria and proposal format
Plugin	Bundled it all into one installable kit with a single starting command
Human	Set the goal, reviewed the work and made the final call

What made it work

- **The right access:** connectors to the tools that held the information.
- **The right know-how:** skills that captured how Brightpath actually works.
- **The right guardrails:** a human approval step before anything left the business.
- **A specific, repeatable task:** a clear goal the business does often, which is the best place to start.

From understanding to action

You now know what the building blocks of modern AI are and how they fit together. Part 2 turns that understanding into decisions: where AI pays off in a business like yours, whether to buy, configure or build, how to use AI safely, and how to move from a first pilot to measurable results.



PART 2

Putting AI to Work

Part 2 turns understanding into decisions. It maps the AI stack in plain language, shows where AI pays off in a business like yours, and helps you choose between buying, configuring or building. It then covers how to use AI safely and how to move from a first pilot to measurable results. It ends with a readiness checklist you can use today.

09 The AI stack, simplified

10 Where AI pays off in an SMB

11 Buy, configure or build

12 Using AI safely

13 From pilot to results

14 AI readiness checklist and glossary

CHAPTER 9

The AI stack, simplified

The "AI stack" is the set of layers that work together to deliver an AI solution, from the computers that run models up to the app your team uses. Small businesses rarely build the lower layers; they rent them as services. Your real choices sit near the top: which apps your team uses, which workflows to automate, and what data and tools to connect.

09

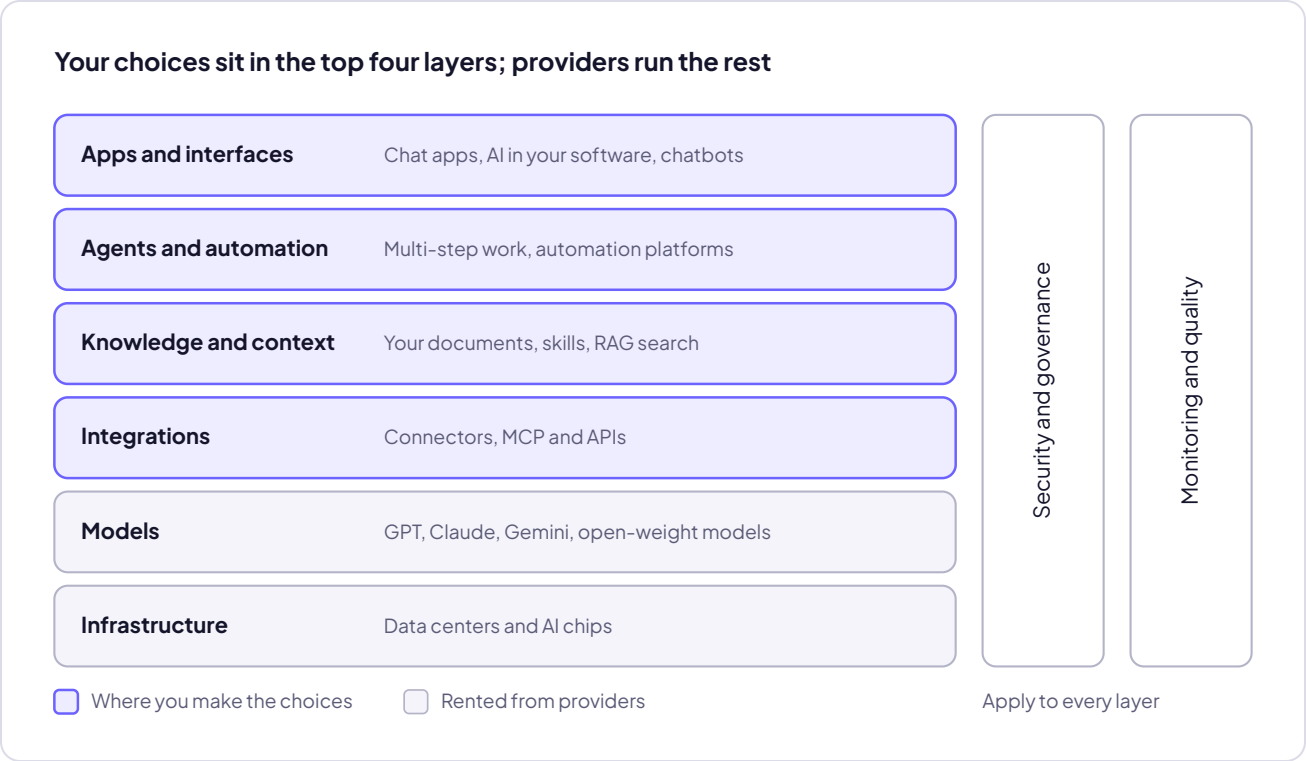
Aptimatic

IN THIS CHAPTER

The six layers, top to bottom

Giving AI your company knowledge

Where SMBs make decisions



The top four layers are where your decisions create value; models and infrastructure are rented as services, and security and monitoring apply throughout.

The six layers, top to bottom

1. **Apps and interfaces.** Where people meet AI: chat apps like ChatGPT, Claude or Gemini, AI features built into software you already use (email, CRM, accounting), customer chatbots on your website, and custom apps.
2. **Agents and automation.** The logic that plans and runs multi-step work (Chapter 3). This includes agent features in AI apps and automation platforms such as Zapier, Make or n8n that chain steps together.
3. **Knowledge and context.** What makes AI useful for *your* business: your documents, records and know-how, made available at the right moment. This is where skills (Chapter 6) and document search live.
4. **Integrations.** The connections to your tools and data: connectors and MCP (Chapters 4 and 5) and traditional APIs.
5. **Models.** The AI "brains" from providers such as OpenAI, Anthropic and Google, or open-weight models (Chapter 2).

6. **Infrastructure.** The data centers and specialized chips that train and run models. Cloud and AI providers handle this layer for you.

Two concerns run through every layer: **security and governance** (who can access what, and what's allowed), and **monitoring and quality** (checking that the AI keeps working as expected).

Giving AI your company knowledge

The most common way to give AI access to company knowledge is **retrieval-augmented generation (RAG)**. Instead of retraining a model on your data, which is costly and rarely necessary, the system searches your documents for passages relevant to a question and hands them to the model with the question. The model then answers from your material, ideally citing where it found it.

This is how a support chatbot can answer from your product manuals, or how an assistant can find the right clause in your contracts.

> JARGON **RAG (retrieval-augmented generation).** A technique where AI first looks up relevant information from your documents, then uses it to write its answer. It keeps answers grounded in your own, up-to-date material.

> JARGON **Fine-tuning.** Further training a model on your own examples to change its style or behavior. Useful in specific cases, but most SMBs get better value from good instructions, skills and RAG.

Where SMBs make decisions

Layer	Typical SMB decision	Usually handled by
Apps and interfaces	Which AI apps and plans the team uses	You
Agents and automation	Which workflows to automate, and how much autonomy to give	You, with a partner for complex work
Knowledge and context	Which documents and processes to make available	You, often with a partner
Integrations	Which tools to connect, and with what permissions	You or a partner
Models	Usually chosen through your app; matters more for custom builds	Your app vendor or developer
Infrastructure	Rarely a decision for an SMB	AI and cloud providers

Why this matters for your business

- You don't need to understand every layer in depth. Focus on the top four, where your choices create value.
- Most of the stack is rented, so you can start small and pay as you grow.
- Your data, processes and know-how are what make AI specific to your business; competitors can buy the same models.
- When a vendor pitches a solution, ask which layers it covers and which you still need to provide.

CHAPTER 10

Where AI pays off in an SMB

AI pays off fastest on work that is frequent, repetitive, text-heavy and currently eats skilled people's time. The best first project is not the most impressive one; it's a specific, everyday task where saved hours are easy to see and mistakes are easy to catch.

10

Aptimatic

IN THIS CHAPTER

Use cases by business function

Signs a task is a good fit

Signs to wait

How to pick your first project

Use cases by business function

Function	High-value uses	Typical starting point
Customer service	Answering common questions, drafting replies, summarizing tickets, routing requests	AI-drafted replies that staff review before sending
Sales	Prospect research, call prep, CRM updates, personalized follow-ups, proposals	Automatic call briefs and follow-up drafts
Marketing	Content drafts, repurposing one piece into many, campaign reports, SEO copy	A brand-voice skill for consistent content
Finance and admin	Invoice processing, payment reminders, expense categorizing, reconciliations	Extracting fields from invoices and receipts
Operations	Scheduling, inventory alerts, standard operating procedures, routine reports	A weekly report generated from your systems
HR and people	Job descriptions, onboarding guides, policy Q&A, interview question sets	An internal assistant that answers from your handbook
Leadership	Meeting summaries, market research, decision memos, board updates	Summaries and action items after every meeting

Signs a task is a good fit

- **It happens often:** daily or weekly, not once a year.
- **It follows a pattern:** similar inputs, similar steps, a recognizable "good" result.
- **It's mostly reading and writing:** emails, documents, forms, notes or data.
- **A person can check the result quickly:** reviewing takes far less time than doing.
- **The cost of a mistake is low or catchable:** an error is noticed before it reaches a customer or the books.

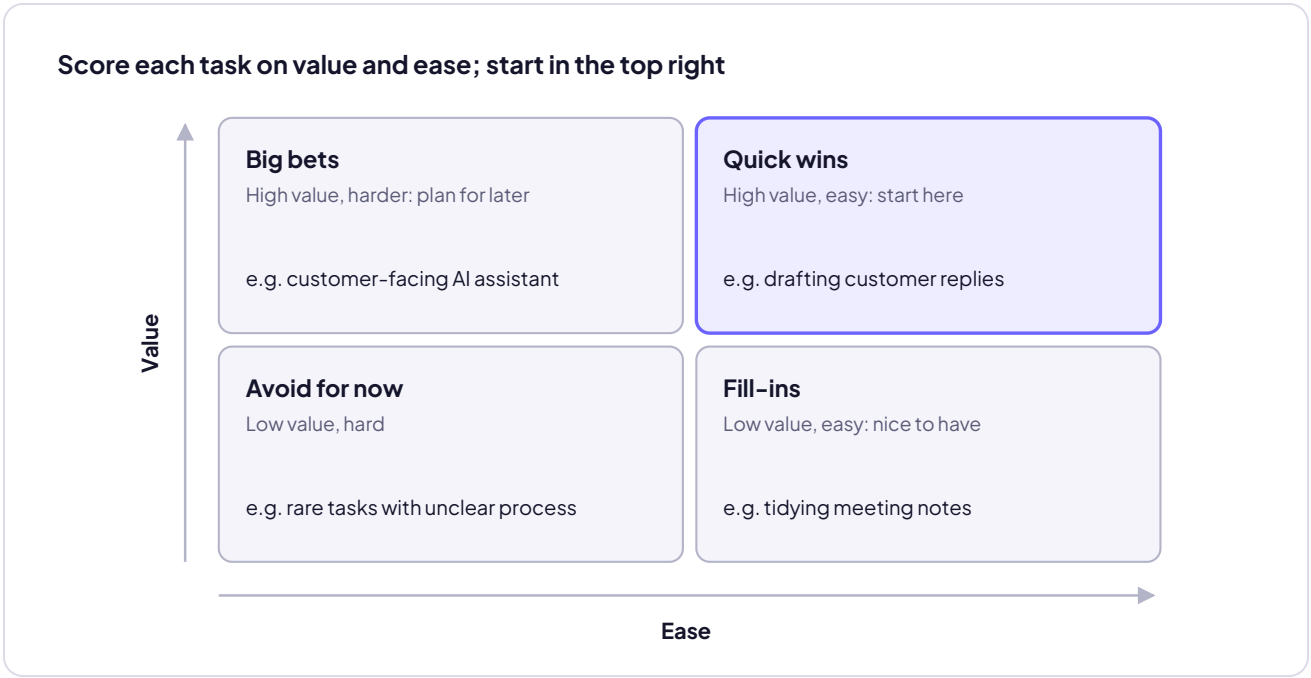
Signs to wait

- The process isn't defined yet, or everyone does it differently. Fix the process first; AI amplifies whatever it's given.
- The task depends on information that isn't written down anywhere.
- A mistake would be serious and hard to spot, such as legal filings or payroll, without strong review steps.

- The volume is tiny, so the setup effort will never pay back.

How to pick your first project

1. **List 10 to 15 candidate tasks.** Ask each team: "What repetitive work takes most of your week?"
2. **Estimate the time each takes** per week across the team.
3. **Score each one** from 1 to 5 on value (time saved, faster response, fewer errors) and on ease (clear process, data available, low risk).
4. **Pick one with high scores on both.** Save the high-value but hard tasks for later, once you've built experience.
5. **Define success up front,** such as "cut average reply time from 4 hours to 1" or "save 6 hours a week on invoice entry."



A simple scoring table is enough. Here's an example layout to fill in:

Task	Hours per week	Value (1–5)	Ease (1–5)	Notes
Example: drafting customer replies				
Example: entering invoice details				
Example: weekly sales report				

Why this matters for your business

- A focused first win builds confidence and budget for the next project.
- Measuring the "before" is essential: without it, you can't prove the improvement.
- The people doing the work today know where the time goes; involve them from the start.
- Clean, consistent processes are a prerequisite. AI makes good processes faster and messy ones messier.

CHAPTER 11

Buy, configure or build

There are three ways to bring AI into a business: buy ready-made tools, configure them to fit your workflows, or build something custom. Most SMBs should start by buying, move to configuring as needs become clearer, and build only where off-the-shelf tools fall short and the payoff justifies it.

11

Aptimatic

IN THIS CHAPTER

The three paths

Comparing the options

When each path makes sense

Questions to ask any AI vendor

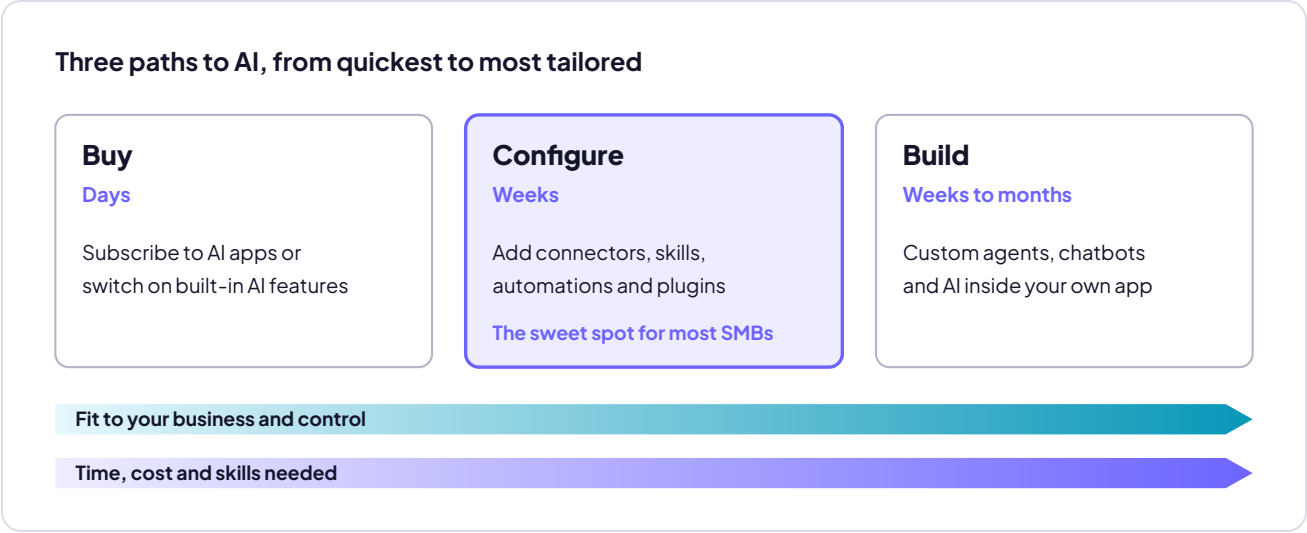
Understanding the total cost

The three paths

1. Buy: off-the-shelf AI tools. Subscribe to AI apps or switch on AI features in software you already use. Examples include business plans for ChatGPT, Claude or Gemini, and AI built into tools like Microsoft 365, Google Workspace, HubSpot or QuickBooks.

2. Configure: connect and customize. Take those tools and tailor them: add connectors to your systems, write skills for your processes, set up projects with your documents, build automations with platforms such as Zapier or Make, or install plugins for each team. Little or no coding is needed.

3. Build: custom AI solutions. Develop something specific to your business, such as a customer-facing assistant trained on your products, an agent that runs a back-office process end to end, or AI embedded in your own app. This uses AI APIs and usually needs developers.



Comparing the options

	Buy	Configure	Build
Time to value	Days	Weeks	Weeks to months
Upfront cost	Low	Low to moderate	Moderate to high
Ongoing cost	Per-user subscriptions	Subscriptions plus some upkeep	Usage-based API fees plus maintenance
Fit to your business	Generic	Good	Exact

	Buy	Configure	Build
Skills needed	Basic	A tech-savvy team member or a partner	Developers or a partner
Control over data and behavior	Vendor's settings	More, through permissions and instructions	Full
Best for	Individual productivity, getting started	Team workflows, connecting your tools	Unique processes, customer-facing products, high volume

When each path makes sense

- **Buy** when the task is common to many businesses (writing, summarizing, research) and a general tool does it well.
- **Configure** when the tool is right but needs your data, your process or your tools to be useful. This is the sweet spot for most SMBs, and the building blocks from Part 1 make it far easier than it used to be.
- **Build** when the workflow is central to how you compete, involves high volume, faces customers, or needs integration that no product offers.

These paths aren't exclusive. Many businesses buy AI apps for everyone, configure connectors and skills for key teams, and build one or two custom tools where it matters most.

Questions to ask any AI vendor

- Is our data used to train your models? Can we opt out?
- Where is our data stored, and for how long?
- Which of our existing tools does it connect to? Does it support MCP?
- What admin controls do we get: user management, permissions, audit logs?
- Can we switch the underlying model, or are we locked in?
- How is pricing structured, and what happens to cost as usage grows?
- What does it do when it's unsure or wrong? Can we review its actions?

Understanding the total cost

Look beyond the subscription or API price. The full cost includes:

- **Setup:** configuration, integration and testing.
- **Usage:** subscriptions, or API fees that scale with volume (Chapter 2).
- **People's time:** training, reviewing AI output and managing the tools.

- **Maintenance:** updating instructions and skills, fixing broken integrations, and keeping up as tools change.

Then compare it with the value: hours saved, faster response times, fewer errors, or revenue you couldn't capture before.

Why this matters for your business

- Start with the simplest path that solves the problem; you can always move up.
- Configuration gives most SMBs the best balance of fit, cost and speed.
- Build only where it creates a lasting advantage or no product fits.
- Avoid lock-in: favor tools built on open standards like MCP and Agent Skills, and ones that let you change models.

CHAPTER 12

Using AI safely

Using AI safely comes down to four habits: protect your data, limit what AI can access, keep a person in charge of important decisions, and write down simple rules your team follows. None of this needs a large compliance department; a one-page policy and the right settings cover most of the risk for a small business.

IN THIS CHAPTER

Protecting your data

Limiting access and permissions

Keeping a human in the loop

Defending against AI-specific risks

A one-page AI policy

The regulatory picture

12

Aptimatic

Protecting your data

- **Use business plans, not personal accounts.** Business and enterprise plans from the major providers typically exclude your data from model training and add admin controls. Confirm this in the provider's terms.
- **Decide what never goes into AI.** Common examples: customer payment details, passwords, government ID numbers, health information and confidential legal matters, unless the tool is approved for that data.
- **Know where data goes.** Ask vendors where data is stored, how long it's kept and who can access it (Chapter 11's vendor questions).
- **Remove what you don't need.** Strip personal details from documents before sharing them with AI when the task doesn't need them.

Limiting access and permissions

Agents and connectors (Chapters 3 to 5) act with real access to your systems, so treat them like a new employee's logins:

- Grant the minimum access needed, and start with read-only where possible.
- Use your AI app's admin settings to control which connectors, skills and plugins staff can use.
- Install connectors, skills and plugins only from trusted sources.
- Review and remove unused access every few months.

Keeping a human in the loop

Decide in advance which actions always need a person's approval. A practical rule of thumb:

Risk level	Examples	Human role
Low	Internal drafts, summaries, research, brainstorming	Spot-check occasionally
Medium	Customer emails, social posts, reports for clients	Review before it goes out
High	Payments, contracts, pricing changes, deleting data, hiring decisions	Approve every action; AI recommends only

Defending against AI-specific risks

- **Hallucinations:** require sources for factual claims, and check figures, names and quotes before they leave the business.
- **Prompt injection:** be cautious when agents read emails, websites or documents from outside the business. Keep approval steps on sensitive actions so hidden instructions can't do damage.
- **Bias:** AI can reflect biases in its training data. Take particular care when AI touches decisions about people, such as hiring, lending or pricing.
- **Over-reliance:** keep the skills to do critical work without AI, and watch for staff accepting output without reading it.

A one-page AI policy

A short written policy gives your team clarity. It should cover:

1. **Approved tools:** which AI apps and plans staff may use for work.
2. **Data rules:** what information may and may not be shared with AI.
3. **Review rules:** which outputs need a human check before use, based on the risk table above.
4. **Disclosure:** when to tell customers that content or replies are AI-assisted.
5. **Ownership:** who approves new tools and connectors, and who to ask with questions.
6. **Reporting:** how to flag a mistake or a concern.

Review it every six months; tools and rules change quickly.

The regulatory picture

AI regulation is still taking shape and differs by location. This overview reflects the situation as of November 2026. It's general information, not legal advice: check with a lawyer for your situation, and use a public tracker, such as the IAPP's, for updates.

European Union

- **Who it covers.** The EU AI Act applies both to businesses that build AI ("providers") and to those that use it ("deployers"), including some businesses outside the EU when their AI's output is used there. Most SMBs are deployers, with far lighter duties than AI developers.
- **AI literacy, in force since February 2, 2025.** Businesses using AI must take measures to help the staff who use it understand it well enough to use it competently. A 2026 amendment softened the wording from ensuring a sufficient level of literacy to supporting its development (ActuIA). Basic training, as described in Chapters 1 and 13, goes a long way.

- **Transparency, in force since August 2, 2026.** People must be told when they're interacting with an AI system such as a chatbot, and deepfakes must be labeled. A customer chatbot on your website therefore needs a clear disclosure. A separate December 2, 2026 deadline for machine-readable marking of AI-generated content applies to AI developers whose systems were already on the market, not to most SMBs (SetAIComply).
- **High-risk uses, delayed.** Obligations for "high-risk" uses, such as hiring, credit and education, now apply from December 2, 2027, under an amendment in force since July 27, 2026 (Verifywise).

United States

- **No single federal AI law.** A December 2025 executive order set up a Justice Department task force to challenge state AI laws, but as of late October 2026, no state AI law had been overridden. State laws still apply until a court or Congress says otherwise (Astraea).
- **A growing state patchwork,** mostly focused on AI in employment decisions and transparency. Illinois has made discriminatory use of AI in hiring, promotion and other employment decisions a civil-rights violation, with notice requirements, since January 1, 2026; the detailed notice rules are still being finalized. Colorado replaced its earlier AI act with a narrower law that takes effect January 1, 2027. California, New York City and Texas, among others, have their own rules (Epstein Becker Green).

Existing laws still apply everywhere

Privacy, consumer protection, anti-discrimination and advertising rules apply to AI-assisted work just as they do to anything else. Two points are worth knowing:

- **Marketing claims.** Consumer protection regulators, including the US Federal Trade Commission, have acted against misleading claims about what AI products can do. Keep claims about your own AI-powered offerings accurate.
- **Ownership of AI output.** In the US, material generated entirely by AI generally can't be copyrighted, while work with meaningful human authorship can. Keep a human hand in creative work you want to own.

The safest approach is to treat AI used in decisions about people, such as hiring, firing, credit or pricing, as high-risk wherever you operate: keep a human decision-maker, document how the AI is used and tell people when it's involved.

Why this matters for your business

- Most AI risk for an SMB is managed with good settings, tight permissions and clear review rules.
- A one-page policy prevents the most common mistakes, such as pasting sensitive data into personal accounts.
- Regulations are evolving fast; AI in hiring and other decisions about people deserves the most care.
- Responsible use builds trust with customers, which is itself a competitive advantage.

CHAPTER 13

From pilot to results

The surest path to results is a small, time-boxed pilot on one well-chosen task, measured against a clear "before," then expanded only once it works. Most AI projects that disappoint skip one of these steps: they start too big, never measure, or never bring the team along.

13

Aptimatic

IN THIS CHAPTER

Running a pilot

Measuring return on investment

What to track

Bringing your team along

Scaling what works

Running a pilot

1. **Pick the task** using the scoring approach in Chapter 10.
2. **Measure the baseline.** Before changing anything, record how long the task takes, how often it happens, and its error or rework rate.
3. **Set a success target and a time box.** For example: "Within six weeks, cut time spent on customer replies by 40%, with no drop in satisfaction."
4. **Choose a small group.** Two to five people who do the task today and are open to trying something new.
5. **Set it up simply.** Start with the buy or configure path (Chapter 11): the right app, a connector or two, and a skill with your instructions.
6. **Run it and gather feedback weekly.** What worked, what didn't, where did the AI get things wrong? Refine the instructions as you go.
7. **Compare against the baseline.** Decide to expand, adjust or stop.

Stopping is a valid result. A pilot that shows a task isn't a good fit costs far less than a full rollout that fails.



Measuring return on investment

Keep ROI simple and honest. Compare the value created with the full cost (Chapter 11):

$$\text{ROI} = \frac{\text{Value gained} - \text{Total cost}}{\text{Total cost}}$$

Value usually comes from:

- **Time saved,** valued at the cost of the people whose time is freed up.
- **Speed,** such as faster replies or quicker quotes that win more business.
- **Quality,** meaning fewer errors, less rework and more consistent output.
- **Capacity,** taking on more work or customers without hiring.

An illustrative example: a team saves 6 hours a week on invoice entry. At $40 an hour, that's $240 a week, or about $12,000 a year. If the tools and setup cost $3,000 in the first year, the ROI is 300%. Use your own numbers, and include review time, since people still check the AI's work.

What to track

Measure	Example	How to track it
Time per task	Minutes to draft a proposal	Quick time logs before and during the pilot
Volume	Tickets handled per person per day	Your existing systems
Quality	Edits needed, errors caught, customer ratings	Reviewer notes, satisfaction scores
Adoption	How many people use it each week	AI app admin dashboards
Cost	Subscriptions, API fees, setup hours	Invoices and usage reports

Bringing your team along

Technology is usually the easy part; people make or break adoption.

- **Explain the why.** Be clear that the goal is to remove tedious work, not people. Uncertainty about jobs is the biggest barrier to adoption.
- **Involve the people who do the work.** They know where time is wasted, and they'll spot problems early.
- **Train for the basics.** Clear prompting, checking output and knowing what not to share (Chapters 1 and 12).
- **Find champions.** One enthusiastic person per team who helps colleagues and shares wins.
- **Celebrate early wins** with real numbers: hours saved, faster turnaround.

- **Make it routine.** Build AI steps into how the work is done, not an optional extra.

Scaling what works

Once a pilot succeeds:

1. **Standardize it.** Capture the final instructions as a skill, and package the setup as a plugin for the team (Chapters 6 and 7).
2. **Roll it out in stages,** team by team, keeping the review steps in place.
3. **Pick the next task** from your scored list, using what you learned.
4. **Review regularly.** Check results quarterly, and update tools and instructions as models improve.

Why this matters for your business

- A small, measured pilot is the lowest-risk way to prove AI's value.
- Without a baseline, you can't show results; measure before you start.
- Adoption depends on people: explain, involve, train and celebrate.
- Each success makes the next one faster, because skills, connectors and plugins are reusable.

CHAPTER 14

AI readiness checklist and glossary

Use this checklist to see where your business stands and what to do next. Every unticked item is a practical next step, and each links back to the chapter that covers it.

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IN THIS CHAPTER

AI readiness checklist

Glossary

AI readiness checklist

Foundations

- [ ] Our team uses business-grade AI accounts, not personal ones (Chapter 12)
- [ ] We've written down which AI tools are approved for work (Chapter 12)
- [ ] Staff know what information must never be shared with AI (Chapter 12)
- [ ] At least a few people have had basic training in prompting and checking output (Chapter 1)

Opportunities

- [ ] We've listed our most time-consuming repetitive tasks (Chapter 10)
- [ ] We've scored them on value and ease, and picked a first project (Chapter 10)
- [ ] We've measured how long that task takes today (Chapter 13)
- [ ] We've defined what success looks like, with a number and a deadline (Chapter 13)

Tools and data

- [ ] We know which of our existing tools offer connectors or MCP servers (Chapters 4 and 5)
- [ ] Our key documents and processes are written down and up to date (Chapter 9)
- [ ] We've decided whether to buy, configure or build for our first project (Chapter 11)
- [ ] We've asked our vendors the key questions about data and lock-in (Chapter 11)

Safeguards

- [ ] We've decided which AI actions always need human approval (Chapter 12)
- [ ] AI tools and connectors have only the access they need (Chapters 5 and 12)
- [ ] We take extra care, and keep a human decision-maker, where AI touches decisions about people (Chapter 12)
- [ ] Someone owns AI decisions and reviews our policy at least twice a year (Chapter 12)

People

- [ ] We've explained to the team why we're using AI and what it means for them (Chapter 13)
- [ ] Each team has an AI champion (Chapter 13)
- [ ] We share results and wins regularly (Chapter 13)

Glossary

Term	Plain-language meaning
Agent (agentic AI)	AI that can plan steps and use tools to complete a task, not just answer questions
API	A way for software to talk to an AI model directly; used by custom tools and automations
Connector	A ready-made link between an AI app and a business tool, usually built on MCP
Context window	The maximum amount of text an AI can consider at once
Fine-tuning	Further training a model on your own examples to change its style or behavior
Generative AI	AI that creates new content such as text, images or code
Hallucination	When AI states false or invented information as if it were fact
Human in the loop	A person reviews or approves AI's work before it takes effect
Large language model (LLM)	The AI engine behind tools like ChatGPT, Claude and Gemini, trained on vast amounts of text
MCP (Model Context Protocol)	The open standard for connecting AI apps to business tools and data
Multimodal	Able to work with images, audio or video as well as text
Open-weight model	A model you can download and run on your own systems
Plugin	A bundle of skills, connectors and commands set up for a role or workflow
Prompt	The instruction or question you give an AI
Prompt injection	Hidden instructions in content an AI reads, meant to trick it
RAG (retrieval-augmented generation)	AI looks up relevant passages in your documents, then answers using them
Reasoning model	A model that works through problems step by step before answering
Skill	Packaged instructions and resources that teach AI to do a task your way
Token	A small chunk of text; the unit AI uses to measure input, output and cost
Tool use	AI triggering an action in other software, such as searching or sending an email
Training cutoff	The date after which a model has no built-in knowledge

NEXT STEP

How Aptimatic can help

Aptimatic helps small and medium businesses turn the ideas in this handbook into working results, in plain language and without jargon. Wherever you are with AI, we can meet you there.



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IN THIS CHAPTER

Getting started

Where you are	How we help	Related chapters
Getting your team confident with AI	On-demand classes on writing effective prompts, spotting unreliable output and using AI safely	1
Choosing the right models and tools	Tool and vendor evaluation that tests candidates on your real tasks and budget	2
Connecting AI to your systems	Setting up and governing connectors, and building custom MCP servers for in-house tools	4, 5
Capturing how your business works	Turning your key processes into skills, so AI matches your standards from the first draft	6
Rolling AI out team by team	Packaging workflows into plugins, with a private catalog of approved tools	7
Automating multi-step work	Designing and building custom agents, with approval steps and safeguards built in	3, 8
Finding where AI will pay off	AI readiness assessment and a clear, jargon-free roadmap	10, 14
Running a pilot and scaling it	Project management from kickoff to launch, plus post-launch support	13

Getting started

The best first step is a short conversation about one workflow that takes too much of your team's time. From there, we can recommend where AI will pay off fastest and what it would take.

To start that conversation, visit aptimatic.io.

READY WHEN YOU ARE

Put AI to work in your business.

Book a free, no-commitment 30-minute discovery call.
We'll find the workflow where AI will pay off fastest.

aptimatic.io · support@aptimatic.io

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